I would brief him in the Conference Room at Lok Kalyan Marg. Because of the Covid restrictions, the PM would sit at one end of the table, and I would brief from the other end. The PM would listen patiently, never once interrupting, asking questions only at the end. When asked, during the initial days of the crisis, whether we had any options, I gave my assurance that we had generated quid pro quo (QPQ) options, not only in Eastern Ladakh but all across the Northern Front. Towards the end, time permitting, the PM would recount some experiences from his Chief Minister days, his vision for the future or of how once while travelling he had been impressed by the conduct of the person serving him tea, who he learnt later had been in the NCC (as had our PM). All these were not idle reminiscences, but had some significance, a lesson in management perhaps or a way forward. On return to my office, I would jot down these points and ponder over them to see what needed to be done. There was never any tension in these interactions and I would usually return with a much lighter heart. Of course, I always kept the RM informed of these interactions and what had transpired in them.

The fifth round of talks held on 2 August remained inconclusive. The Chinese side revived their proposal of a partial pullback, while we reiterated our stance of full restoration of the status quo ante. This was followed by a WMCC meeting on 24 July, in which the same point was restated and both sides agreed that an early and complete disengagement was essential to normalize relations between the two countries, which had hit an all-time low after the Galwan incident.[12] The NSA, Shri Ajit Doval, had also been speaking to his counterpart Mr Wang Yi, the Chinese Foreign Minister and Special Representative, from time to time, including on 6 July just prior to the disengagement at PP-14, and he had also conveyed the

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